Actors and political economy

Who has power over this problem, what do they want, and who is not heard?



Today

By the end of today, you will have

Built a power-interest and incentive matrix for your case that includes the groups with an interest but no voice.

- Map actors by power over and interest in the outcome.
- State each key actor's incentive and likely response to change.
- Identify groups with high interest and little power or voice.
- Explain how rules in use differ from rules on paper.

Competencies: D3 · D4

Session plan

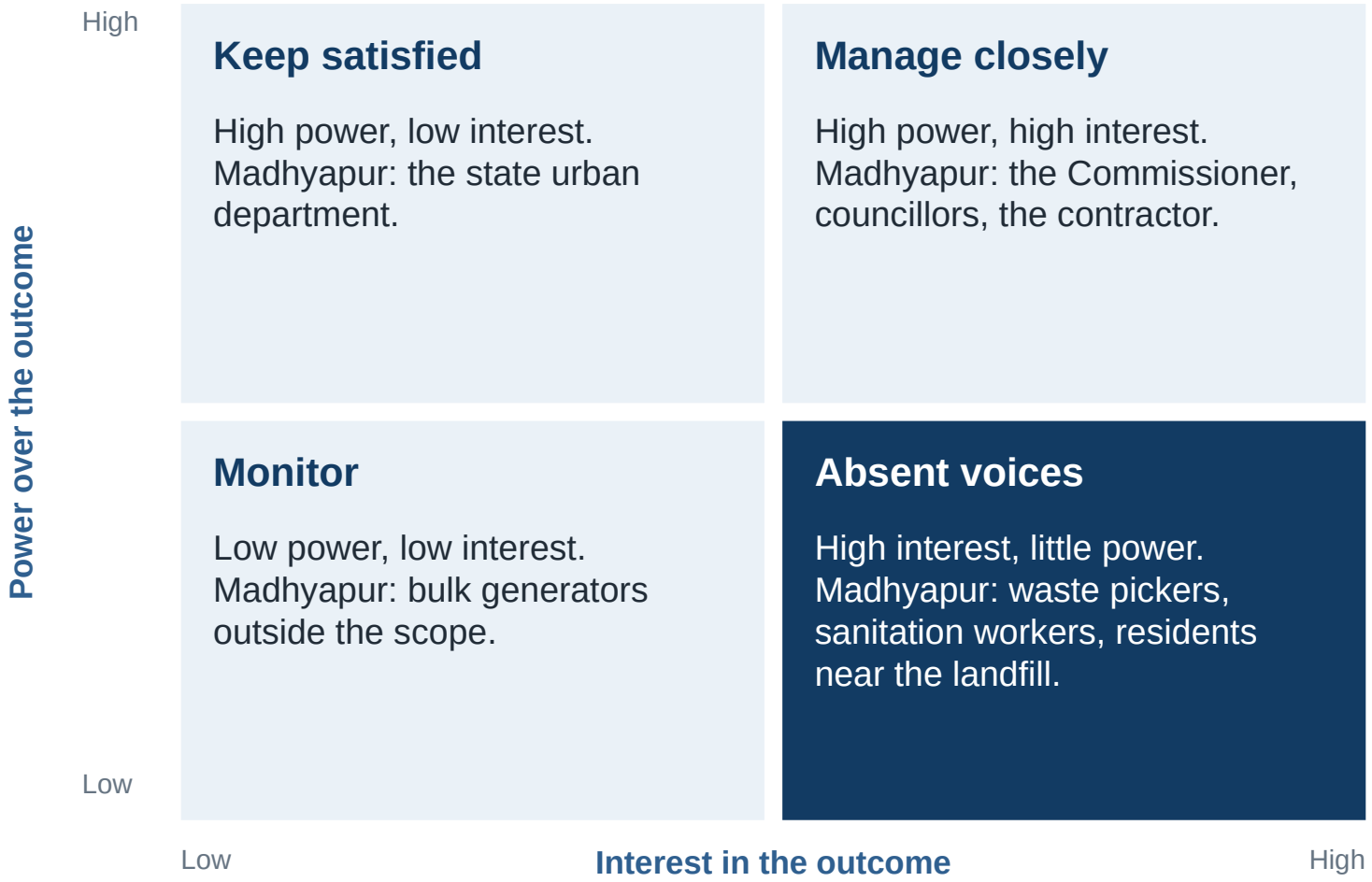
10 min	**Opening problem**
20 min	**Concept: power, interest, incentives**
15 min	**Demonstration: Madhyapur actors**
40 min	**Activity: stakeholder negotiation**
25 min	**Own case: incentive matrix**
10 min	**Debrief and exit task**

Opening problem

- **A city announces a congestion charge for private cars entering its centre at peak hours. List everyone who will care. Who will fight it? Who will not even be asked?**

Two minutes, then call out names.

The power-interest map, with absent voices



The standard grid calls the bottom-right box keep informed. The Lab calls it absent voices, because a map that only manages the powerful can reproduce the exclusions that policy analysis should detect.

Incentives explain behaviour better than attitudes

Actor	What they want	What the system rewards now	Likely response to a contract change
Contractor	Profit, contract renewal	Weight collected, fast trips	Resist, or seek higher rates
Crews	Finish routes, keep jobs	Speed	Comply if time and compartments allow
Councillors	Re-election, visible service	Clean streets, few complaints	Support if no penalties fall on voters
Ward inspectors	Manageable workload, no blame	Reporting, not results	Support if given authority
Waste pickers	Access to recyclables, safety, recognition	Nothing: they work informally	Gain from separated dry waste, if included

Write what the system rewards, not what people should want.

Rules on paper and rules in use

- **The 2016 rules require households to separate waste. In Madhyapur, the rule that actually governs behaviour is: the truck takes everything.**

Look for the rules people actually follow. Ask what a crew member or an inspector does on an ordinary Tuesday, and why.

A thinker for your case

Elinor Ostrom and Michael Lipsky

Governing the Commons (1990); Street-Level Bureaucracy (1980)

Ostrom showed that the rules people actually follow often differ from the formal rules. Lipsky showed that frontline workers make policy through the discretion they exercise under pressure.

The question it puts to your case

Which rules actually govern behaviour here, and what will frontline workers really do?

Answer it in one sentence in your workbook today.

Political economy in four questions

1. **Who gains from the current arrangement?**

   Madhyapur: the contractor is paid for weight, including mixed waste.

2. **Who would lose from change, and can they block it?**

   The contractor could litigate or slow collection; councillors fear visible disruption.

3. **Who would gain but is not organised?**

   Waste pickers and residents near the landfill.

4. **What would make change feasible?**

   A transition plan, a coalition with resident associations, and timing away from ward elections.

Activity: Stakeholder negotiation simulation

Experience how power, interest and incentives shape what is feasible, by negotiating a contested policy in role.

Scenario

A large city proposes a congestion charge for private cars entering its central business district at peak hours, with the revenue going to buses. Roles: the municipal commissioner, the traffic police, a bus operators' association, a car owners' group, a street vendors' association, an environmental group, and bus commuters, who have no seat at the table unless someone gives them one.

What to do

1. Read your role card privately: interests, power and red lines.
2. Round one, ten minutes: each role states its position in one minute.
3. Round two, fifteen minutes: negotiate a workable design in coalitions.
4. The commissioner announces a decision and says whom it favours.
5. Step out of role: place every actor on the power-interest map.

Time 40 minutes

Groups Groups of seven or eight, one role each

Output A negotiated design and a completed power-interest map

Your case: Worksheet 3.2

Stakeholder and incentive matrix

1. List every actor in and beyond your delivery chain who affects or is affected by the problem.
2. Place each on the power-interest map.
3. For each key actor, write what they want, what the system rewards and their likely response to change.
4. Identify at least one group with high interest and little voice.
5. Record one rule in use that differs from the rule on paper, with evidence.

Hand in

Worksheet 3.2 by the start of Day 8.

Quality check

At least eight actors are mapped.

Tag every claim in your Analyst's Ledger: fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

What to take away

1. Map power and interest, then ask who has no voice.
2. Incentives explain behaviour better than attitudes. Write what the system rewards.
3. The rules in use can differ sharply from the rules on paper.
4. Feasibility is political: find who can block change and what would bring them along.

Exit task Name the actor most able to block change in your case, and their incentive to do so.

Before the next session

Independent work

Find one published source that records the experience of the absent voice in your case, such as a field study, a social audit, testimony to a committee or credible reporting. Note what it adds to your map. About 45 minutes.

Read

Lipsky, Street-Level Bureaucracy (1980), preface and chapter 1, or the introduction to the expanded edition.

Next

Day 8: Prioritising issues

Tomorrow we decide which branches of your tree deserve your limited time.